

Mirror Image

Into the fray

Written By Levi Boswell,

2196, midway across the Pacific, toward artificial island fortress city Parie, 3rd PyAi war

Brash, loud, thunderous noise sunders your ears, which stimulates the feeling of intense fear, lurching yourself awake upright in your bed. A small bunk in a metal bulkhead cabin of a large naval vessel. You stare at a sealed metal door that has a large steering handle at the center of the long, narrow room. before gathering the slightest of thoughts to trigger the automated neurological display, which flickers on at the edges of your vision. Only to see it crack and blur when the second ear-shattering noise rumbles through the hull directly above your head. Shocked, swarmed with emotions of horror and fear. The warm watery tears touch your cheeks as your vision blurs out temporarily as the bulk ward door unlatches. You starkly remember your parents' faded words in your memory just a night earlier, telling you, "Do not ever leave your room if you hear loud noises. *As the door unlatches, it is locked from the inside.*" The feeling that something is watching you from behind encroaches and the urge to leave intensifies, as the battle of wills rings out in your mind, only to lose the will to resist the neurological conflict. Then a cluster of smaller explosions trembles the metal ceiling above you, the heaps of dust gliding to the ground. At that moment, an unknown will dictates your decisions, your display crackles and distorts in your vision as you attempt to call your parents through the neurological visual display. Only to see the 'not connected to service' icon and whenever you open the application. The distortion of the crackling in your vision moves to block

the overlay, which doesn't help as you run barefoot to your parent's room. Sprinting down the hall, everything comes to a halt as a pinpoint migraine-like pain erupts from the back of your head where your implant is located; just as you see the left side of the hull explode into flame as if a projectile impacted and penetrated the hull leaving a massive metal shell blocking the entire hallway through; in response to the pain you lose focus trip and tumble to the ground grasping your head with both hands to soften the fall. Your heads-up display now shows a red warning symbol with the '!' blinking. You heed not what it says, as your attention is preoccupied as you see a staircase leading up the deck. Both your mind and the heart yearn for safety, seeing this as a way around the obstacle, only to pass by the labelled sign which reads main deck, and the arrow pointing up the stairs. Reaching the top of the stairs, looking out onto the deck of the aircraft carrier to see fire, metal, and debris, with the smells of oil and burning flesh through the door. The rancid smell makes you hold back the acid reflux as you bring your hands to cover your mouth and nose to suppress the gut-wrenching experience. The first moving thing grabs your immediate attention after recollecting yourself, at the bow of the ship, you look out to a humanoid U.M.I.V (Un-manned, Mechanized, Infantry, Vehicle) flailing, about but striking nothing when it swung using a blade and projectile weapon system, its rocket pod already empty.

The humanoid machine was standing in an active, black, ferrofluid-like substance, which it was also covered in. It moved like a living creature, bubbling and moving in chaotic patterns. UMIV's sleek and slender design made even the ugliest movements look smooth and graceful. Its head, which was as shallow to the shoulders, was riddled with cameras underneath to protect equipment from projectiles. A large wire connects its sword's hilt to the mech's back where a large battery-like cylinder is hung horizontally across the lower back. The vehicle's lower body had buckled legs, which had a similar shape to that of a hind leg of a quadrupedal animal. The overall size of the vehicle stood no taller than the tallest basketball player. It was wearing gear like a modern 21st century infantry unit, a vest with pockets for ammunition and

medical supplies. Your vision zooms in much like a camera to take a closer look; the supplies were mechanical tools and another smaller opaque cylinder with some labelling "toxic, dangerous, conductive," with the name "living metal nanomachines". The unit was also equipped with a variety of other gear from the top down. The machine looked to be engaged in combat, but your eyes could not see the opponent it was engaged with. All you could see was the spout of black, liquid, gush and fall to the ground whenever the red-hot, long blade was swung through the air. The massive hulk paused a moment and turned its head 180 degrees to look dead at you. A shiver went down your spine as you stared into the many cameras and sensors. It was a fleeting feeling as everything became numb from head to foot. A Roaring aircraft zoomed overhead, dropping a torpedo into the ocean just on the other side of the deck, followed by a howling explosion and gushing of water in the wake, which caused the ship to shake, as you look out to see the direction of the blast to see the fleet of warships in combat or sinking. You feel like you are being paralyzed but still moving, except not by one's own free will. Your legs begin to walk out onto the deck and across to where the gush of water was. Your feet walking through broken glass and metal, but no pain is felt. Then your bloody, soaked feet walking threw the new saltwater left by a bomb shockwave should have made it sting even more. But you could not feel a thing. On the way across the deck, you notice some other UMIV's however, their bodies lay dead on the floor of the deck, oozing the same black liquid from the gaping wounds in the chest cavity; some occasionally sparking, others on fire. There must have been at least 5 dozen or so that you passed by, not before coming to the edge of the deck looking into the ocean. To see a massive 5-leaf flower blooming just under the surface of the water. It was mesmerizing; the purple flower petals were calling to you. Twisting and changing the shade of your favourite colour. At this point, it was too late as your heart screams to run away, your mind and body are no longer yours. You take a step to fall into its center and be caught by the flower... something grabs your shoulder and lurches you back with incredible

force onto the deck; to see a man in military uniform holding you down with a strand of black liquid as your body violently reacts to escape. All you could do was watch.

“Gotcha,” the voice said.

The man waves his hand as the black liquid comes to life and solidifies from behind him, holding my legs and arms to the deck as he pulls out a wire from the back of his neck and plugs it into the back of my head. I could hear him talk over an intercom through the visor he was wearing.

“You want me to do what?!” the intercom said.

“I want a direct link; add her to the network, it is the only option.” He roared into the mic over the noise.

“You’re supposed to be piloting me! Not adding another user to a highly classified and potentially fatal situation just to risk saving a single passenger over the rest of the ship!? ...

“Your opinion is overruled,” he sharply replied.

“Your funeral.” Was the U.H.M.I.V’s snarky, sassy reply over the intercom.

The jolt of information surged through my mind. My head felt hot, like it was burning in sunlight with no sunscreen on a hot day. My vision was filled with windows and pop-ups, loading bars, warning lights. What I remember most was the pain. Imagine a migraine but 100 times worse.

“Common, common...” he muttered urgently. The feeling of warm blood dripping onto my cheek. A tremendous clanging of metal over the gunfire and roars of battle happening out across the deck.

“Well, there goes an arm,” the intercom said. The sass was real.

“Just a little longer 7. Almost there.” The man replied desperately.

Just like that, the numbness I felt disappeared as I stopped struggling. Before I could thank the man for the fleeting pain and the regaining of control of myself. I was lifted over his back, my vision as clear as day. Still numb to physical pain, but it must have been on purpose. Looking out at the flower. To find out what was a flower was now a tower fleshy metal plant-like monster hiding just below the water. It has five petals blooming with hundreds of humanoid creatures covering its petals headless, and inside was the black of night, moving in the most uncanny of ways. Its tendrils latched onto the ship as the creatures climbed up it to the ship like spreading pollen to a passing bee. Its stem goes down into the deep as far as I could see. There were other flower-like stems, some of which had no heads and looked wilted and dead. All the creatures share one thing in common: they were machines that looked like grafted flesh was misshapen to make them look more organic. The black liquid coursed threw the flesh like blood, and they had no face, just a garbled black liquid for heads and sharp pieces of metal and hanging wires, they looked like a factory rushed them out or were half finished, though looks were deceiving. As I look over as the man carries me, running, back to the other side of the ship to check on the UMIV. It had lost its arm and was standing in wear, the tendrils were still latched onto the ship, preventing the carrier from moving. Cutting down every creature with its blade, anything that came on deck was quickly dispatched. The UMIV is surrounded by dead corpses as the enemy faces mutate into weapons of all types as they attack the sparking UMIV with melee and ranged attacks targeting the head and chest. The battle, a dance between being overwhelmed and not letting one reach the deck. Human remains were nowhere to be seen, although I could see uniforms cute up, slashed, firearms, blood, and mangled bits. Even at the U.H.M.I.V's best, many spiders (the humanoid headless machine-like creepy crawly things they moved like spiders) rushed past, ignoring him and heading straight for us. I screamed in panic,

“shoot,” the man carrying said glancing back.

“Well, can you blame the H.A.I (Human Augmented Intelligence) without an arm.” Was 7’s the U.H.M.I.V’s sassy reply.

It was weird at first, that I saw everything the two of them could see and hear and feel.

The man was just as terrified as I was.

“Hey, Delta, where’s my backup!” the pilot holding me called over the intercom. Some crackling came over with gunfire.

“We were tied up on deck 13 still. We are dropping like flies down here! We lost 130 passengers so far to mind control!” a soldier of some sort shouted. Before, a gushing impaling sound was heard over the intercom, and the line went dead. As the ship began to lean to the side with the tentacle latched on, another intercom voice ran out,

“this is Captain Raven Smith, Jack the ship has only has one sucker latched on, I need you to cut it loose your our only pilot left with an operational unit.” The man carrying me replied, being on the command deck holding on to anything to keep him upright, surrounded with other officers handling coms.

“What happened to Air support sir?”, as the man holding me seemed more or less unfazed by the dramatic shift, using the black liquid as a tail-like appendage to keep balance.

“They’ve got bigger fish to fry right now, Lieutenant. We just picked up on radar one of them big suckers a hundred clicks out and the few birds I just sent at best give you a 10 minutes before were robo food. Get us out of this minefield now!” Raven ordered, then one of his officers noted, “Sir, we’re taking on water on the port side,”, Raven ordered, “Close off the bulk heads they are trying to cripple our movement to get at the refugees.”, “yes sir!” The officer then moved

to a system and started closing off the bulkheads, and thus ended the transmission. The humanoid creatures that 7 was fighting crawled like four-legged spiders encroaching rapidly on the pilot Jack and me.

“Hey girl, you got a name?” Jack asked, panting, still running as the machines encroach, still about 12 seconds out of projectile range.

“It’s Diana,” I reply shakily.

“I need you to listen carefully Diana. I am going to put your down, and I want you to run as fast as you can to the door outlined on the —” a voice cuts him short on the intercom.

“Hey buddy I hear ya need a hand, mind if we lend ya a one!” the voice said. As two marines popped up the stairs covered in blood and black goo, and started laying covering fire. Their red-hot shots make popping sounds upon impact with little effect other than black goo bleeding out of the monsters, occasionally hitting a joint and causing one to collapse into a disgusting crawl, slowing them down.

“We can take care of your ‘princess’ Jack just get the flesh suckers off this ship!” the other one shouted across the deck.

“Ok, new plan,” Jack said to me, “Just run to Dave and Bradly over there and they will keep you safe.” As he puts me down, I nod sheepishly and start running with ringing in my ears. Running into Dave’s arms and looking back to see Jack, turns and faces the encroaching spiders. before I being escorted by Dave and Bradly to where the rest of the passengers are. On the way, I had another display from a drone circling about Jack, along with another window with 7’s vision, which was a lot to take in. I watched them work with no real choice being directly linked to them.

Jack had his own external battery strapped similarly to 7's cylindrical container. The black liquid came from under his uniform, right where the tailbone would be. He prepared a stance as if he were holding a Katana-like sword and hilt on his side. The liquid tail replicated into a smaller version of 7's sword. It formed right into his hand. The black line split off and connected to the battery.

"Let's make it rain," Jack smirked to help him feel better at the face of certain death, the first time he fought not piloting threw his suit 7 in a long while.

"This would be so much easier if I didn't have to be doing this without the safety net." He thought to himself.

The first spider shot a spike of metal from its head at him like a machine gun. Before the shots could hit him, they liquified and dispersed like mist a few feet in front of him, like rain. It was like Jack could control the liquid with his mind. The spider leaped, materializing a spike from its head, intending to jab it straight threw his heart. a quick reaction and flick as the orange hot blade unsheathes. Jack dodges under the attack, pivoting with one foot while swinging the blade, cutting the belly of the spider open, killing it. Then the next spider leaps at Jack from behind. Using the vision of the drone, reached out with his free hand stretched out over and a quick, violent motion behind him, in that motion, the black goo from a dead UMIV sprang to life, impaling horizontally through the next attacker, ending it in a single blow. One after another, each spider falls to his blade and magic. His prowess matched that of 7, as their moves are nearly identical.

"7, we've got to unlatch the ship, can you cut the tendrils still attached?" Jack asked over the coms, just beheading one spider, which still tries to scratch at him. Though before it could, it is sliced in half to finish it off with his blade.

"Maybe if I had two arms. The probability is 23.76% for all three tendrils. Lower if you consider their crawling with spiders." 7 replied.

"ok, plan B then. Keep them busy." Jack stated.

"oh no you don't the amount of computing required to connected stably to that many nano machines while having a third party linked is pushing you implants you moron!" 7 retorted.

Although it was too late as Jack had already cut his way threw to where 7 was, in a similar and elegant dance of beauty and death. Hacking away at the endless stream of bad guys crawling onto the deck, trying their best to avoid 7. The fluidity of Jack's moves, striking while dodging, swapping between blade and gun, was a dance of beauty like a lotus hitting a pond, barely making a ripple in the water as it slowly spun in place.

"Cover me," as Jack's blade returns to its tail and dissipates, leaving behind the orange hot blade clanging to the ground inactive. All the active black liquid around 7 begins to move uniformly with Jack's thoughts. A warning light appears and a sound notification "99.3% NPU utilization (neural processing unit) usage temperatures rising above 87.3 degrees" as the black liquid creates a large saw blade spinning and slowly cutting threw the first tendril and anything that tries to stop it. The tendril was about the average person's height in diameter.

"At your rate, you'll get threw two before overheating and we all die from BMI (brain machine interface) meltdown." 7 said body blocking a spike shot coming in at Jack, standing on the deck close enough to keep the liquid active and solidified to the shape he needed. As he did, I began to feel my back of my head get hot.

"Who said anything about me finishing?" Jack smirked. As 7 frantically encircles, cutting down every enemy even at the cost of being damaged, as the gaping wounds left by the spiders were

adding up, hydraulic fluid was leaking on the ground. A large snapping sound and the first cable released.

"R.I.G Battery low 16%, Integrity 32%" was the next warning as the temperature rose to 88.4 degrees. Jack starts on the second tendril from the single flower.

"Prepare the engine, the moment we are loose, punch it." Captain Raven ordered, looking down from the deck above, windows shattered and heavily damaged.

"Yes, sir, Captain," the helmsman replied.

"Delta, Charlie, Foxtrot, Huckleberry, Alpha, Beta teams guard the remaining refugees in the hangar. All other teams get on deck and cover that pilot!" Captain Raven ordered over the coms. Noticing the convergence of the spider's hive mind, retargeting their attention to the lone pilot on deck.

Both Soldiers and spiders began the fight by first spurring onto the deck from every orifice, rushing to either protect or to try and eliminate Jack and 7 just as the first tendril is cut. It was like the fight that was below deck was no longer a concern for both sides. ~500 navy blue uniforms and Air Force support staff armed, ~200 marines, and a handful of pilots, and no additional U.H.M.I.V's. The marines were geared in addition to implants and had advanced combat gear. Their gear looked like an older generation than Jack's. All sides spurring onto the main deck with blades drawn, some marines laying down heavy gun fire to enemy stragglers racing from below the decks as the second tendril hits the water, the crew on deck were outnumbered 2:1. As support staff handled logistics and supplies alongside laying down fire.

“MOVE, MOVE, MOVE!” a Sargent orders just before getting shot, shouting over the heavy firefight as they make their way to Jack and engage in hand-to-hand combat. One man became riddled with spear-like projectiles from the neck down. Another cut in two clean pieces. Those who managed to make it to 7, who still managed to fight with 7 having a mangled leg and no arm, were a few battle-hardened soldiers, as both sides locked in battle, taking heavy losses on both sides. Whenever a human dropped dead, it was soon covered head to toe in the black goo nano machines, then its killer loomed over the dead body. The ichor seeped into every pore, causing the head explode, leaving behind a bloody mess and metallic structures replacing the bones, excreting them from the flesh to form its topless black form and pulsating body. The sound the body makes when going threw this process is only something one could dream of in nightmares.

“Shoot the ones replicating!” a distant voice echoed in the background.

“Stop them!” another voice echoed. Among many similar cries being made out over the screams of grown men crying for their mothers lying wounded, screaming in pain, or those about to be replicated praying for mercy. Among others, fueled with hate, curses, rage, as they rush into their deaths, the fight for survival ensued. What I saw that day, many would say it was ‘hell’, to me, those brave men and women they were heroes, every one of them. Why because they gave there lives to save me and my family, is there no greater love than this?

“R.I.G Battery 8%, Integrity 18%,” was the next notification on Jack’s display. In addition to “NPU overheating 95.6 degrees, Safety Shutdown overridden,”

“You got enough power to cut it?” Jack asked, barely able to stand the saw blade enlarged, still pinning halfway through the second tendril.

"It will be close. I've already stored a backup here." 7 takes out a small rectangular chip from his head and hands it to Jack.

"You know me too well," Jack replied.

"Don't make it sound like we're dead--yet, I am currently adapted 76% to your neural patterns and a minority of other human intelligences from past pilots." 7 replied.

"I think they hacked your tutorial program." Jack replied, "It should be higher. Good thing, to I think you will need it" as the second wire crushes into the ocean not before a flesh popping sound is heard and I could feel a sharp object impale my kidney, I look down and check feeling around for a wound but nothing. I look back on the screen to see Jack's point of view of his hand covered in blood. All the black nano machines that are not heated up beyond a tipping point drop into the ocean, losing shape and returning to a liquid. As everything begins to glitch out in my vision.

"GO!" Jack said, waving his arm at 7 to cut the last anchor holding the carrier in place. 7 limps over, then looks over the side of the ship. He does some calculating and limps off. Landing on the tendril, a shaky landing, and started slashing at the wire as he let the enemies continue to attack him, swarming around him.

"Medic!" a soldier cried out. Jack slumps down onto the ground, holding the wound shut, finding cover behind some scrap metal and dead bodies.

Jack coughs up some blood, "Am I going to die?" he asks one of the soldiers with him, trembling in fear and adrenaline.

"You're going to be ok, we just need to stop the bleeding. They only got the kidney lieutenant." The man replied.

7 being torn apart, trying to cut the last wire, losing all functions from the endless intruders still climbing the wire, in a last-ditch effort started a self-destruct sequence using the hydrogen fusion fuel that is used in his mini reactor at 7's core. Allowing his core to jump to insane temperatures and dispersing the heat to all parts of what's left of his body. Melting and frying any nanostructure, including the anchor. However, the meltdown was not enough to break free; the damage to the final tendril was minimal.

"Captain! Jack's wounded and 7 meltdown failed, we are still attached!" The helmsman reported.

"All ahead full speed. let's hope it's enough." Raven ordered. He then spoke over the intercom, "All hands, brace yourselves!" The turbines roared to life as the carrier jerked forward everything on deck shifted violently, causing many to lose their footing and fall to the ground only the remain pilots and spider did the shift not seem to effect as much, the ship then slowed to a halt, as the creaking of steel surges threw the hull of the ship. The helmsman held the ship's steering wheel with all his might to prevent the ship from turning, trying to break free.

"Sir, are Port Side Porpeller is not responding. If we don't get out of here soon, we'll be dead in the water!" one of the officers yelled across at Raven.

mean while on the way back to the deck 3, Dave stopped hearing on deck and yelling over coms "this is Sgt. D. Hue from Huckle berry team, anyone listening?! We Have C4 in a nearby hangar! Do you copy!" he shouted into the handheld radio, looking at Bradly and down at the Daina, kneeling, "he can you relay a message to jack for me?" in a kind- and soft-hearted voice, though you could see the stress in his face and its importance the two of them looked like the read eachothers minds. I replied, "Sure, I think I can do that."

Back on the battlefield of the deck, Jack pulled the soldier tending his wounds to him and shouted over the fighting relaying the message,

“Get some C4! The cable is only holding by a thread!” he shouted. The man, shocked, nodded, pulled out hastily a walkie-talkie and started relaying the message over the intercom. Most of the men on deck were either wounded, killed or turned. Pinned on all sides. Only a handful of marines and the logistics team remain, along with a couple of pilots without RIG’s including Jack. A moment later, A loud amphibious door opened at the front of the ship and out came three speedy pontoon boats manned by a gunner and a driver, each making their way to the tendril that was preventing the ship from moving. The first boat goes down to a smaller flower mine as its petals break over the water and trap the boat, like a Venus flytrap. Allowing its spiders on the inside to do the rest of the work. The other two boats swerve around a couple mines each manning a large machine gun at the front firing at the endless enemies crawling up the line of the last tendril attached to the ship, so one of the pilots on board the pontoons can get a clean shot at throwing 50 lb sticky box of C4 using its tail. As the height of the tendril was far too high for any human to toss. The enemy’s numbers were starting to dwindle on the line, not before realizing that the amalgamation of a group of them was in the middle of transfiguring itself to form a large spike rail gun. To target the pontoon attack boats.

“HURRY, THROW THE LOAD!” a boat driver cried, being the first to notice. What was happening, as the rest of the crew turned to see a morbid scene of flesh and metal before their eyes. The long, large black spike zoomed toward the boat with one of the pilots, just as he made the toss. The spike penetrates the boat completely, tearing it in half, and the pilot too. As the C4 reaches the peak of the throw, sticking to the tendril, the pilot still holding the detonator in hand, floats in the water, dead. Instinctively, the driver of the second boat dives into the water picks up the waterproof detonator and activates it. Causing the ear-shattering explosion and breaking the tendril, as the driver, a moment later, is pulled underwater. And a second spike

impales with perfect accuracy the second boat. The gunner of the second boat kept shooting the spiders away from the load before it detonated. Splitting it in two and drowning the crew by having spiders fall into the water and dragging them under with their weight. The ship then lurches forward, causing a large creaking of metal throughout.

“Captain, look!” one of the crew called out on radar. “The enemy main ship is moving away.” As it would seem, the jets that managed to take off managed a miracle.” Then on coms, one of the jet pilots on coms reported “enemy vessel took significant damage to its hive link, it's now backing down.”

“Good.” Cpt. Raven remarked, “Good work, I don’t think we would live if that snake came after us.” He then continued to one of the officers with him, “The last of the fighter craft managed enough damage to slow it down. How many we have left?” he asked the intelligence officer.

“2 of 12, sir.” The officer replied.

The battle on deck was eventually cleaned up, for the jets to land just before they ran out of fuel, as the wounded were taken to med stations around the ship. The ship made full steam ahead to the main oceanic base. The passengers were accounted for as the carrier made 20 knots heading toward the coast of Parie.

“god bless those who gave their lives today.” Cpt. Raven replied. Taking off his captain’s hat... He then put his hat back on and turned to face an officer,” Get the maintenance crew to start cleaning immediately. This vessel needs to be combat-ready asap. I’ll be in my quarters; I want a report on my desk by tonight.” Captain Raven Ordered.

“Yes, Sir.” The officer replied. That day, the crew of the Aircraft Carrier strike group lost all but the Carrier itself, named Silvertounge, sustained heavy damage, and was carrying 3000

refugees onboard, with a crew of 5000, 1800 airforce, 500 marines, 24 pilots, ~2000 naval, only ½ made it back and 130 refugees were MIA. of the 120 UHMIV's on board all were destroyed.

It wasn't till a few days later that I managed to go and see Jack. My family, mom and dad, were with me when I visited him. Mom and Dad were so happy to see me after Dave reunited me with them. For the rest of the trip to the terminal entrance of the main port, to the underground city network. I'd visit Jack every day and give him something I made and thank him for saving me. usually some freaky drawing. After the months-long uneventful journey when we had to say are true goodbyes, he came to find me just before debarking. He came and gave me a gift and said, "Here, something to remember me by." I'd never forget the events that happened that day. Not that I can, that is. It's all encoded onto a data slate, an external hard drive of sorts for those boomers out there still living back in the 20s. Jack is the reason I decided to join the 3rd-gen pilot program; it's the least I can do after what he has done for me. Diana stood up from her desk, pulling out the same rectangular chip that had an engraved on it, "7 of 500, 2nd gen H.A.I." Ten years have gone by since that day. And a lot has happened; Jack was promoted to captain, among many other things, during the war, he talks a lot about an elf, never knew they were still around. It's a story for another time. That being said, I'd like to end this video log with... my name is Lieutenant Diana Ugisaki, 3rd generation pilot living in the coastal underground city of New Parie. The year is 2151, baby. Log out. "Logging you out of the officer's system software.",

"NO NO NO, 7 that's not what I meant!".

Video log ends...

